

'After having discovered the abode of the masked executioner? Yes, that was a terrible day!'

'Come in, then,' said Athos, interrupting him.

They entered the large apartment, formerly the common one. The tavern, in general, and this room in particular, had undergone great changes; the ancient host of the musketeers, having become tolerably rich for an innkeeper, had closed his shop, and make of this room of which we were speaking, a store-room for colonial provisions. As for the rest of the house, he let it ready furnished to strangers. It was with unspeakable emotion D'Artagnan recognized all the furniture of the chamber of the first story; the wainscoting, the tapestries, and even that geographical chart which Porthos had so fondly studied in his moments of leisure.

'It is eleven years ago,' cried D'Artagnan. '*Mordieu!* it appears to me a century!'

'And to me but a day,' said Athos. 'Imagine the joy I experience, my friend, in seeing you there, in pressing your hand, in casting from me sword and dagger, and tasting without mistrust this glass of sherry. And, oh! what still further joy it would be, if our two friends were there, at the two corners of the table, and Raoul, my beloved Raoul, on the threshold, looking at us with his large eyes, at once so brilliant and so soft!'

'Yes, yes,' said D'Artagnan, much affected, 'that is true. I approve particularly of the first part of your thought; it is very pleasant to smile there where we have so legitimately shuddered in thinking that from one moment to another M. Mordant might appear upon the landing.'

At this moment the door opened, and D'Artagnan, brave as he was, could not restrain a slight movement of fright. Athos understood him, and, smiling—

'It is our host,' said he, 'bringing me a letter.'

'Yes, my lord,' said the good man; 'here is a letter for your honour.'

'Thank you,' said Athos, taking the letter without looking at it. 'Tell me, my dear host, if you do not remember this gentleman?'

The old man raised his head, and looked attentively at D'Artagnan.

'No,' said he.

'It is,' said Athos, 'one of those friends of whom I have spoken to you, and who lodged here with me eleven years ago.'

'Oh! but,' said the old man, 'so many strangers have lodged here!'
'But we lodged here on the 30th of January, 1649,' added Athos, believing he should stimulate the lazy memory of the host by this remark.

'That is very possible,' replied he, smiling; 'but it is so long ago!' and he bowed, and went out.

'Thank you,' said D'Artagnan—'perform exploits, accomplish revolutions, endeavour to engrave your name in stone or bronze with strong swords! there is something more rebellious, more hard, more forgetful than iron, bronze, or stone, and that is, the brain of a lodging-house keeper who has grown rich in the trade;—he does not know me! Well, I should have known him, though.'

Athos, smiling at his friend's philosophy, unsealed his letter.

'Ah!' said he, 'a letter from Parry.'

'Oh! oh!' said D'Artagnan; 'read it, my friend, read it! No doubt it contains news.'

Athos shook his head, and read:

Monsieur le comte.

The king has experienced much regret at not seeing you to-day beside him, at his entrance. His majesty commands me to say so, and to recall him to your memory. His majesty will expect you this evening, at the palace of St James, between nine and ten o'clock.

I am, respectfully, monsieur le comte, your honour's
very humble and very obedient servant,

PARRY.

'You see, my dear D'Artagnan,' said Athos, 'we must not despair of the hearts of kings.'

'Not despair! you are right to say so!' replied D'Artagnan.

'Oh! my dear, very dear friend,' resumed Athos, whom the almost imperceptible bitterness of D'Artagnan had not escaped. 'Pardon me! can I have unintentionally wounded my best comrade?'

'You are mad, Athos, and to prove it, I shall conduct you to the palace; to the very gate, I mean; the walk will do me good.'

'You shall go in with me, my friend; I will speak to his majesty.'

'No, no,' replied D'Artagnan, with true pride, free from all mixture; 'if there is anything worse than begging yourself, it is making others beg for you. Come, let us go, my friend, the walk will be charming; on the way I shall show you the house of M. Monk, who has detained me with him. A beautiful house, by my faith. Being a general in England is better than being a *maréchal* in France, please to know.'

Athos allowed himself to be led along, quite saddened by D'Artagnan's forced attempts at gaiety. The whole city was in a state of joy; the two friends were jostled at every moment by enthusiasts who required them, in their intoxication, to cry out, 'Long live good King Charles!' D'Artagnan replied by a grunt, and Athos by a smile. They arrived thus in front of Monk's house, before which, as we have said, they had to pass on their way to St James's.

Athos and D'Artagnan said but little on the road, for the simple reason that they would have had so many things to talk about if they had spoken. Athos thought that by speaking he should evince satisfaction, and that might wound D'Artagnan. The latter feared that in speaking he should allow some little bitterness to steal into his words which would render his company unpleasant to his friend. It was a singular emulation of silence between contentment and ill-humour. D'Artagnan gave way first to that itching at the tip of his tongue which he so habitually experienced.

'Do you remember, Athos,' said he, 'the passage of the *Mémoires de D'Aubigny*, in which that devoted servant, a Gascon like myself, poor as myself, and, I was going to add, brave as myself, relates instances of the meanness of Henry IV? My father always told me, I remember, that D'Aubigny was a liar. But, nevertheless, examine how all the princes, the issue of the great Henry, keep up the character of the race.'

'Nonsense!' said Athos, 'the kings of France misers? You are mad, my friend.'

'Oh! you are so perfect yourself, you never agree to the faults of others. But, in reality, Henry IV was covetous, Louis XIII, his son, was so likewise; we know something of that, don't we? Gaston carried this vice to exaggeration, and has made himself, in this respect, hated by all who surround him. Henriette, poor

whether he be grateful or not? It is to myself I have rendered a service, by relieving myself of this responsibility, and not to him.'

'Well, I have always said,' replied D'Artagnan, with a sigh, 'that disinterestedness was the finest thing in the world.'

'Well, and you, my friend,' resumed Athos, 'are you not in the same situation as myself? If I have properly understood your words, you allowed yourself to be affected by the misfortunes of this young man; that, on your part, was much greater than it was upon mine, for I had a duty to fulfil; whilst you were under no obligation to the son of the martyr. You had not, on your part, to pay him the price of that precious drop of blood which he let fall upon my brow, through the floor of the scaffold. That which made you act was heart alone—the noble and good heart which you possess beneath your apparent scepticism and sarcastic irony; you have engaged the fortune of a servant, and your own, I suspect, my benevolent miser! and your sacrifice is not acknowledged! Of what consequence is it? You wish to repay Planchet his money. I can comprehend that, my friend: for it is not becoming in a gentleman to borrow from his inferior, without returning to him principal and interest. Well, I will sell *La Fête* if necessary, and if not, some little farm. You shall pay Planchet, and there will be enough, believe me, of corn left in my granaries for us two and Raoul. In this way, my friend, you will be under obligations to nobody but yourself; and, if I know you well, it will not be a small satisfaction to your mind to be able to say, "I have made a king!" Am I right?'

'Athos! Athos!' murmured D'Artagnan, thoughtfully, 'I have told you more than once that the day on which you will preach I shall attend the sermon; the day on which you will tell me there is a hell—*Mordieu*! I shall be afraid of the gridiron and the pitch-forks. You are better than I, or rather, better than anybody, and I only acknowledge the possession of one quality, and that is, of not being jealous. Except that defect, damme, as the English say, if I have not all the rest.'

'I know no one equal to D'Artagnan,' replied Athos; 'but here we are, having quietly reached the house I inhabit. Will you come in, my friend?'

'Eh! why this is the tavern of the "Corne du Cerf," I think,' said D'Artagnan. 'I confess I chose it on purpose. I like old acquaintances; I like to sit down on that place, whereon I sank, overcome by fatigue, overwhelmed by despair, when you returned on the 31st of January.'

'Oh! our million was spent long ago,' said Athos, laughing in his turn.

'I understand; it was frittered away in satin, precious stones, velvet, and feathers of all sorts and colours. All these princes and princesses stood in great need of tailors and dressmakers. Eh! Athos, do you remember what we fellows spent in equipping ourselves for the campaign of La Rochelle, and to make our appearance on horseback? Two or three thousand livres, by my faith! But a king's robe is the more ample; it would require a million to purchase the stuff. At least, Athos, if you are not treasurer, you are on good footing at court.'

'By the faith of a gentleman, I know nothing about it,' said Athos, simply.

'What! you know nothing about it?'

'No! I have not seen the king since we left Dover.'

'Then he has forgotten you, too! *Mordieu*! That is shameful!'

'His majesty has had so much business to transact.'

'Oh!' cried D'Artagnan, with one of those intelligent grimaces which he alone knew how to make, 'that is enough to make me recover my love for Monsieur Giulio Mazairini. What, Athos! the king has not seen you since then?'

'No.'

'And you are not furious?'

'I! why should I be? Do you imagine, my dear D'Artagnan, that it was on the king's account I acted as I have done? I did not know the young man. I defended the father, who represented a principle—sacred in my eyes, and I allowed myself to be drawn towards the son from sympathy for this same principle. Besides, he was a worthy knight, a noble creature, that father; do you remember him?'

'Yes; that is true; he was a brave, an excellent man, who led a sad life, but made a fine end.'

'Well, my dear D'Artagnan, understand this; to that king, to that man of heart, to that friend of my thoughts, if I durst venture to say so, I swore at the last hour to preserve faithfully the secret of a deposit which was to be transmitted to his son, to assist him in his hour of need. This young man came to me; he described his destitution; he was ignorant that he was anything to me save a living memory of his father. I have accomplished towards Charles II what I promised Charles I; that is all! Of what consequence is it to me, then,

woman, might well be avaricious, she who did not eat every day, and could not warm herself every winter; and that is an example she has given to her son Charles II, grandson of the great Henry IV, who is as covetous as his mother and his grandfather. See if I have well traced the genealogy of the misers?'

'D'Artagnan, my friend,' cried Athos, 'you are very rude towards that eagle race called the Bouthons.'

'Eh! and I have forgotten the best instance of all—the other grandson of the Bernais, Louis XIV, my ex-master. Well, I hope he is miserly enough, he who would not lend a million to his brother Charles! Good! I see you are beginning to be angry. Here we are, by good luck, close to my house, or rather that of my friend, M. Monk.'

'My dear D'Artagnan, you do not make me angry, you make me sad; it is cruel, in fact, to see a man of your deserts out of the position his services ought to have acquired; it appears to me, my dear friend, that your name is as radiant as the greatest names in war and diplomacy. Tell me if the Luyes, the Ballegardes, and the Bassompierres have merited, as we have, fortunes and honours? You are right, my friend, a hundred times right.'

D'Artagnan sighed, and preceded his friend under the porch of the mansion Monk inhabited, at the extremity of the city. 'Permit me,' said he, 'to leave my purse at home; for if in the crowd those clever pickpockets of London, who are much boasted of, even in Paris, were to steal from me the remainder of my poor crowns, I should not be able to return to France. Now, content I left France, and wild with joy I should return to it, seeing that all my prejudices of former days against England have returned, accompanied by many others.'

Athos made no reply.

'So, then, my dear friend, one second, and I will follow you,' said D'Artagnan. 'I know you are in a hurry to go yonder to receive your reward, but, believe me, I am not less eager to partake of your joy, although from a distance. Wait for me.' And D'Artagnan was already passing through the vestibule, when a man, half servant, half soldier, who filled in Monk's establishment the double function of porter and guard, stopped our musketeer, saying to him in English:

'I beg your pardon, my Lord d'Artagnan!'

'Well,' replied the latter: 'what is it? Is the general going to dismiss me? I only needed to be expelled by him.'

These words, spoken in French, made no impression upon the person to whom they were addressed, and who himself only spoke an English mixed with the rudest Scots. But Athos was grieved at them, for he began to think D'Artagnan was not wrong.

The Englishman showed D'Artagnan a letter: 'From the general,' said he. 'Aye! that's it, my dismissal!' replied the Gascon. 'Must I read it, Athos?'

'You must be deceived,' said Athos, 'or I know no more honest people in the world but you and myself.'

D'Artagnan shrugged his shoulders and unsealed the letter, while the impassible Englishman held for him a large lantern, by the light of which he was enabled to read it.

'Well, what is the matter?' said Athos, seeing the countenance of the reader change.

'Read it yourself,' said the musketeer.

Athos took the paper and read:

Monsieur D'Artagnan.

The king regrets very much you did not come to St Paul's with his cortège. He missed you, as I also have missed you, my dear captain. There is but one means of repairing all this. His majesty expects me at nine o'clock at the palace of St James's: will you be there at the same time with me? His gracious majesty appoints that hour for an audience he grants you.

This letter was from Monk.

'Well, but you, in some degree, deserved a little burning, my friend.'

'How so? What, for having saved King Charles's million?'

'What million?'

'Ah, that is true! you never knew that, my friend; but you must not be angry, for it was my secret. That word "*Remember*" which the king pronounced upon the scaffold.'

'And which means "souviens-toi!"'

'Exactly. That was signified. "Remember there is a million buried in the vaults of Newcastle Abbey, and that that million belongs to my son."'

'Ah! very well, I understand. But what I understand likewise, and what is very frightful, is, that every time his majesty Charles II will think of me, he will say to himself: "There is the man who came very near to making me lose my crown. Fortunately I was generous, great, full of presence of mind." That will be said by the young gentleman in a shabby black doublet, who came to the château of Blois, hat in hand, to ask me if I would give him access to the king of France.'

'D'Artagnan! D'Artagnan!' said Athos, laying his hand on the shoulder of the musketeer, 'you are unjust.'

'I have a right to be so.'

'No—for you are ignorant of the future.'

D'Artagnan looked his friend full in the face, and began to laugh. 'In truth, my dear Athos,' said he, 'you have some sayings so superb, that they only belong to you and M. le Cardinal Mazarin.'

Athos frowned slightly.

'I beg your pardon,' continued D'Artagnan, laughing, 'I beg your pardon if I have offended you. The future! Nein! what pretty words are words that promise, and how well they fill the mouth in default of other things! *Mordieu!* After having met with so many who promised, when shall I find one who will give? But, let that pass!' continued D'Artagnan. 'What are you doing here, my dear Athos? Are you the king's treasurer?'

'How—why the king's treasurer?'

'Well, since the king possess a million, he must want a treasurer. The king of France, although he is not worth a sou, has still a superintendent of finance, M. Fouquet. It is true, that, in exchange, M. Fouquet, they say, has a good number of millions of his own.'

‘*Mordieux!* for all the expense I incurred. I have ruined myself, my friend, ruined myself for the restoration of this young prince who has just passed, cantering on his isabella coloured horse.’

‘The king does not know you have ruined yourself, my friend; but he knows he owes you much.’

‘And say, Athos, does that advance me in any respect? for, to do you justice, you have laboured nobly. But I—I who in appearance marred your combinations, it was I who really made them succeed. Follow my calculations closely; you might not have, by persuasions or mildness, convinced General Monk, whilst I so roughly treated this dear general, that I furnished your prince with an opportunity of showing himself generous: this generosity was inspired in him by the fact of my fortunate mistake, and Charles is paid by the restoration which Monk has brought about.’

‘All that, my dear friend, is strikingly true,’ replied Athos.

‘Well, strikingly true as it may be, it is not less true, my friend, that I shall return—greatly beloved by M. Monk, who calls me dear captain all day long, although I am neither dear to him nor a captain;—and much appreciated by the king, who has already forgotten my name;—it is not less true, I say, that I shall return to my beautiful country, cursed by the soldiers I had raised with the hopes of large pay, cursed by the brave Planchet, of who I have borrowed a part of his fortune.’

‘How is that? What the devil had Planchet to do in all this?’

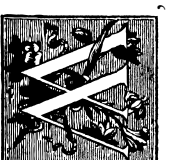
‘Ah, yes, my friend; but this king, so spruce, so smiling, so adored, M. Monk fancies he has recalled him, you fancy you have supported him, I fancy I have brought him back, the people fancy they have reconquered him, he himself fancies he has negotiated his restoration; and yet nothing of all this is true, for Charles II, king of England, Scotland, and Ireland, has been replaced upon the throne by a French grocer, who lives in the Rue des Lombards, and is named Planchet. And such is grandeur! “Vanity!” says the Scripture: “Vanity, all is vanity.”’

Athos could not help laughing at this whimsical outbreak of his friend.

‘My dear D’Aragnan,’ said he, pressing his hand affectionately, ‘should you not exercise a little more philosophy? Is it not some further satisfaction to you to have saved my life as you did by arriving so fortunately with Monk, when those damned parliamentarians wanted to burn me alive?’

Chapter XXXIII

The Audience



‘ELL?’ cried Athos with a mild look of reproach, when D’Aragnan had read the letter addressed to him by Monk.

‘Well!’ said D’Aragnan, red with pleasure, and a little with shame, at having so hastily accused the king and Monk. ‘This is a politeness,—which leads to nothing, it is true, but yet it is a politeness.’

‘I had great difficulty in believing the young prince ungrateful,’ said Athos. ‘The fact is, that his present is still too near his past,’ replied D’Aragnan; ‘after all, everything to the present moment proved me right.’

‘I acknowledge it, my dear friend, I acknowledge it. Ah! there is your cheerful look returned. You cannot think how delighted I am.’

‘Thus you see,’ said D’Aragnan, ‘Charles II receives M. Monk at nine o’clock; he will receive me at ten; it is a grand audience, of the sort which at the Louvre are called “distributions of court holy water.” Come, let us go and place ourselves under the spout, my dear friend! Come along.’

Athos replied nothing; and both directed their steps, at a quick pace, towards the palace of St James’s, which the crowd still surrounded, to catch, through the windows, the shadows of the courtiers, and the reflection of the royal person. Eight o’clock was striking when the two friends took their places in the gallery filled with courtiers and politicians. Every one looked at these simply-dressed men in foreign costumes, at these two noble heads so full of character and meaning. On their side, Athos and D’Aragnan, having with two glances taken the measure of the whole assembly, resumed their chat.

A great noise was suddenly heard at the extremity of the gallery,—it was General Monk, who entered, followed by more than twenty officers, all eager

for a smile, as only the evening before he was master of all England, and a glorious to-morrow was looked to, for the restorer of the Stuart family.

'Gentlemen,' said Monk, turning round, 'henceforward I beg you to remember that I am no longer anything. Lately I commanded the principal army of the republic; now that army is the king's, into whose hands I am about to surrender, at his command, my power of yesterday.'

Great surprise was painted on all the countenances, and the circle of adulators and suppliants which surrounded Monk an instant before, was enlarged by degrees, and ended by being lost in the large undulations of the crowd. Monk was going into the ante-chamber as others did. D'Artagnan could not help remarking this to the Comte de la Fère, who frowned on beholding it. Suddenly the door of the royal apartment opened, and the young king appeared, preceded by two officers of his household.

'Good evening, gentlemen,' said he. 'Is General Monk here?'

'I am here, sire,' replied the old general.

Charles stepped hastily towards him, and seized his hand with the warmest demonstration of friendship. 'General,' said the king, aloud, 'I have just signed your patent,—you are Duke of Albemarle; and my intention is that no one shall equal you in power and fortune in this kingdom, where—the noble Montrose excepted—no one has equalled you in loyalty, courage, and talent. Gentlemen, the duke is commander of our armies of land and sea; pay him your respects, if you please, in that character.'

Whilst every one was pressing round the general, who received all this homage without losing his impassibility for an instant, D'Artagnan said to Athos: 'When one thinks that this duchy, this commander of the land and sea forces, all these *grands seigneurs*, in a word, have been shut up in a box six feet long and three feet wide—'

'My friend,' replied Athos, 'much more imposing *grands seigneurs* are confined in boxes still smaller,—and remain there forever.'

All at once Monk perceived the two gentlemen, who held themselves aside until the crowd had diminished; he made himself a passage towards them, so that he surprised them in the midst of their philosophical reflections. 'Were you speaking of me?' said he, with a smile.

'My lord,' replied Athos, 'we were speaking likewise of God.'

'Athos!' cried D'Artagnan, 'you here!' And the two friends seized each other's hands.

'You here!—and being here,' continued the musketeer, 'you are not in the midst of all these courtiers, my dear comte! What! you, the hero of the fête, you are not prancing on the left hand of the king, as M. Monk is prancing on the right? In truth, I cannot comprehend your character, nor that of the prince who owes you so much!'

'Always scornful, my dear D'Artagnan!' said Athos. 'Will you never correct yourself of that vile habit?'

'But you do not form part of the pageant?'

'I do not, because I was not willing to do so.'

'And why were you not willing?'

'Because I am neither envoy nor ambassador, nor representative of the king of France; and it does not become me to exhibit myself thus near the person of another king than the one God has given me for a master.'

'*Mordieu!* you came very near to the person of the king, his father.'

'That was another thing, my friend; he was about to die.'

'And yet that which you did for him—'

'I did it because it was my duty to do it. But you know I hate all ostentation. Let King Charles II, then, who no longer stands in need of me, leave me to my rest, and the shadow; that is all I claim of him.'

D'Artagnan sighed.

'What is the matter with you?' said Athos. 'One would say that this happy return of the king to London saddens you, my friend; you who have done at least as much for his majesty as I have.'

'Have I not,' replied D'Artagnan, with his Gascon laugh, 'have I not done much for his majesty, without any one suspecting it?'

'Yes, yes, but the king is well aware of it, my friend,' cried Athos.

'He is aware of it!' said the musketeer bitterly. 'By my faith! I did not suspect so, and I was even a moment ago trying to forget it myself.'

'But he, my friend, will not forget it, I will answer for him.'

'You tell me that to console me a little, Athos.'

'For what?'

‘What a fine trade is that of king!’ said this man, so completely absorbed in contemplation that he stopped in the middle of the road, leaving the cortège to file past. ‘Now, there is, in good truth, a prince all bespangled over with gold and diamonds, enamelled with flowers like a spring meadow; he is about to plunge his empty hands into the immense coffer in which his now faithful—but so lately unfaithful—subjects have amassed one or two cartloads of ingots of gold. They cast bouquets enough upon him to smother him; and yet, if he had presented himself to them two months ago, they would have sent as many bullets and balls at him as they now throw flowers. Decidedly it is worth something to be born in a certain sphere, with due respect to the lowly, who pretend that it is of very little advantage to them to be born lowly.’ The cortège continued to file on, and, with the king, the acclamations began to die away in the direction of the palace, which, however, did not prevent our officer from being pushed about.

‘*Mordieux*’ continued the reasoner, ‘these people tread upon my toes and look upon me as of very little consequence, or rather of none at all, seeing that they are Englishmen and I am a Frenchman. If all these people were asked,—“Who is M. d’Aragnan?” they would reply, “*Nescio vos.*” But let any one say to them, “There is the king going by,” “There is M. Monk going by,” they would run away, shouting,—“Vive le roi!” “Vive M. Monk!” till their lungs were exhausted. And yet,’ continued he, surveying, with that look sometimes so keen and sometimes so proud, the diminishing crowd,—‘and yet, reflect a little, my good people, on what your king has done, on what M. Monk has done, and then think what has been done by this poor unknown, who is called M. d’Aragnan! It is true you do not know him, since he is here unknown, and that prevents your thinking about the matter! But, bah! what matters it! All that does not prevent Charles II from being a great king, although he has been exiled twelve years, or M. Monk from being a great captain, although he did make a voyage to Holland in a box. Well, then, since it is admitted that one is a great king and the other a great captain,—“Hurrah for King Charles II!”—“Hurrah for General Monk!”’ And his voice mingled with the voices of the hundreds of spectators, over which it sounded for a moment. Then, the better to play the devoted man, he took off his hat and waved it in the air. Some one seized his arm in the very height of his expansive loyalty. (In 1660 that was so termed which we now call royalism.)

Monk reflected for a moment, and then replied gayly: ‘Gentlemen, let us speak a little of the king likewise, if you please; for you have, I believe, an audience of his majesty.’

‘At nine o’clock,’ said Athos.

‘At ten o’clock,’ said D’Aragnan.

‘Let us go into this closet at once,’ replied Monk, making a sign to his two companions to precede him; but to that neither would consent.

The king, during this discussion so characteristic of the French, had returned to the centre of the gallery.

‘Oh! my Frenchmen!’ said he, in that tone of careless gaiety which, in spite of so much grief and so many crosses, he had never lost. ‘My Frenchmen! my consolation!’ Athos and D’Aragnan bowed.

‘Duke, conduct these gentlemen into my study. I am at your service, messieurs,’ added he in French. And he promptly expedited his court, to return to his Frenchmen, as he called them. ‘Monsieur d’Aragnan,’ said he, as he entered his closet, ‘I am glad to see you again.’

‘Sire, my joy is at its height, at having the honour to salute your majesty in your own palace of St James’s.’

‘Monsieur, you have been willing to render me a great service, and I owe you my gratitude for it. If I did not fear to intrude upon the rights of our command general, I would offer you some post worthy of you near our person.’

‘Sire,’ replied D’Aragnan, ‘I have quitted the service of the king of France, making a promise to my prince not to serve any other king.’

‘Humph!’ said Charles, ‘I am sorry to hear that; I should like to do much for you; I like you very much.’

‘Sire—’

‘But, let us see,’ said Charles with a smile, ‘if we cannot make you break your word. Duke, assist me. If you were offered, that is to say, if I offered you the chief command of my musketeers?’ D’Aragnan bowed lower than before.

‘I should have the regret to refuse what your gracious majesty would offer me,’ said he; ‘a gentleman has but his word, and that word, as I have had the honour to tell your majesty, is engaged to the king of France.’

‘We shall say no more about it, then,’ said the king, turning towards Athos, and leaving D’Aragnan plunged in the deepest pangs of disappointment.

'Ah! I said so!' muttered the musketeer. 'Words! words! Court holy water! Kings have always a marvellous talent for offering us that which they know we will not accept, and in appearing generous without risk. So be it!—triple fool that I was to have hoped for a moment!'

During this time, Charles took the hand of Athos. 'Comte,' said he, 'you have been to me a second father; the services you have rendered to me are above all price. I have, nevertheless, thought of a recompense. You were created by my father a Knight of the Garter—that is an order which all the kings of Europe cannot bear; by the queen regent, Knight of the Holy Ghost—which is an order not less illustrious; I join to it that of the Golden Fleece sent me by the king of France, to whom the king of Spain, his father-in-law, gave two on the occasion of his marriage; but in return, I have a service to ask of you.'

'Sire,' said Athos, with confusion, 'the Golden Fleece for me! when the king of France is the only person in my country who enjoys that distinction?'

'I wish you to be in your country and all others the equal of all those whom sovereigns have honoured with their favour,' said Charles, drawing the chain from his neck; and I am sure, comte, my father smiles on me from his grave.'

'It is unaccountably strange,' said D'Artagnan to himself, whilst his friend, on his knees, received the eminent order which the king conferred on him—'it is almost incredible that I have always seen showers of prosperity fall upon all who surrounded me, and that not a drop ever reached me! If I were a jealous man, it would be enough to make one tear one's hair, parole d'honneur!'

Athos rose from his knees, and Charles embraced him tenderly. 'General!' said he to Monk—then stopping, with a smile, 'pardon me, duke, I mean. No wonder if I make a mistake; the word duke is too short for me, I always seek some title to lengthen it. I should wish to see you so near my throne, that I might say to you, as to Louis XIV, my brother! Oh! I have it; and you will almost be my brother, for I make you viceroy of Ireland and Scotland, my dear duke. So, after that fashion, henceforward I shall not make a mistake.'

The duke seized the hand of the king, but without enthusiasm, without joy, as he did everything. His heart, however, had been moved by this last favour. Charles, by skilfully husbanding his generosity, had given the duke time to wish, although he might not have wished for so much as was given him.

'*Mordieu!*' grumbled D'Artagnan, 'there is the shower beginning again! Oh! it is enough to turn one's brain!' and he turned away with an air so

Chapter XXXII

Athos and D'Artagnan Meet Once More at the Hostelry of the 'Corne du Cerf'



HE king of England made his entrée into Dover with great pomp, as he afterwards did in London. He had sent for his brothers; he had brought over his mother and sister. England had been for so long a time given up to herself—that is to say, to tyranny, mediocrity and nonsense—that this return of Charles II, whom the English only knew as the son of the man whose head they had cut off, was a festival for three kingdoms. Consequently, all the good wishes, all the acclamations which accompanied his return, struck the young king so forcibly that he stooped and whispered in the ear of James of York, his younger brother, 'In truth, James, it seems to have been our own fault that we were so long absent from a country where we are so much beloved!' The pa-
geant was magnificent. Beautiful weather favoured the solemnity. Charles had regained all his youth, all his good humour; he appeared to be transfigured; hearts seemed to smile on him like the sun. Amongst this noisy crowd of courtiers and worshippers, who did not appear to remember they had conducted to the scaffold at Whitehall the father of the new king, a man, in the garb of a lieutenant of musketeers, looked, with a smile upon his thin, intellectual lips, sometimes at the people vociferating their blessings, and sometimes at the prince, who pretended emotion, and who bowed most particularly to the women, whose bouquets fell beneath his horse's feet.